Keeping Shelter Clients Informed about the Disaster and Red Cross Services

Guidance for workers at shelters on effectively meeting the information needs of clients

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: Shelter Shift Supervisors, Shelter Workers

Considerations

- Update clients frequently to help them understand the disaster, their situation, the shelter, and how to begin moving towards recovery.
  - Regular communication helps stop rumors or inaccurate information.
- Client meetings create a better shelter experience and build a sense of community.
- Helpful tools for communication include bulletin boards, posters and signage, newsletters, and television and newspapers access.
- Related **Shelter Activity Standards**:
  - Shelter Operations
  - Shelter Safety and Client Standards

What to do

Establish an Information Area

- In an area near Reception, provide information to clients in the form of fliers and bulletin board postings.
- Provide daily updates on weather, reunification, disaster situation, upcoming events at the shelter, available community resources and services including where services are available to support livestock and other large animals.
- Review the fliers provided by partner organizations to ensure they are appropriate for clients and align with our mission.
- Make sure all information is accessible to all clients.
  - Engage support from Headquarters as needed to communicate with clients with disabilities and other access and functional needs, including those whose first language is not English.

Create a list of talking points to answer common client questions

- Seek guidance from HQ Sheltering Manager to ensure appropriate messaging.
- Review and update on appropriate intervals.

Host client meetings

- Be sure meetings are are accessible to all clients, including those who are Deaf or Hard of Hearing, have limited English proficiency, or have other communication accessibility needs.
- In the meetings, cover the following:
  - Disaster updates, recovery information and any known timeline about the shelter status
  - Volunteer opportunities at the shelter

    - Concerns that are affecting the client experience at the shelter
    - Shelter rules and safety information such as:
        - The location of fire extinguishers
        - Evacuation routes
        - The Shelter Emergency Action Plan
        - How to keep personal items and valuables safe
- Allow time for client questions and suggestions and for discussion of issues that clients wish to raise for the Red Cross to address.

Control rumors and incorrect information

- Anticipate that clients may be feeling uncertainty
- Inform your supervisor of any rumors you believe DRO leadership needs to address
- Communicate any talking points you receive

Pet information

- Ensure all information about community-based pet services is available at the pet area.

Related Information

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

Sharing Key Information Between the Shelter and the HQ Sheltering Manager
Types of information and methods of communication shared between shelters and DRO headquarters.

Creating a Client-First Sheltering Environment
Steps for workers in shelters are to build a climate of putting clients first

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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